B2 Reading

Fact or opinion?

Separate what can be checked from what the writer believes, a key skill for news, reviews and exam texts.

A **fact** can be checked and shown to be true or false. An **opinion** is what someone thinks or feels. Most texts mix the two, and good readers notice where one ends and the other begins.

Signals of opinion	Examples
Opinion phrases	*I believe, in my view, it seems that, clearly*
Judgement adjectives	*best, worst, amazing, disappointing, unfair*
Modal verbs of advice or prediction	*should, ought to, will probably*
Generalisations	*Everyone knows… Nobody wants…*

Text

The new metro line opened in March and carries about 40,000 passengers a day. Tickets cost 2 riyals, half the price of a taxi ride across the city. It is the best thing to happen to public transport in years. Clearly, the government should build a second line as soon as possible, because nobody wants to sit in traffic any more.

Numbers are not always facts. *About 40,000 passengers* can be checked; *the best thing in years* cannot, even though it sounds certain.

Common mistake. Treating confident language as fact. Words like *clearly* and *obviously* often introduce an opinion the writer wants you to accept without proof.

Practice

Write F (fact) or O (opinion).

1. The new metro line opened in March.
2. It carries about 40,000 passengers a day.
3. Tickets cost 2 riyals.
4. It is the best thing to happen to public transport in years.
5. The government should build a second line.
6. Nobody wants to sit in traffic any more.

▼ Show answers

1. F
2. F
3. F
4. O
5. O
6. O (a generalisation that cannot be proved)